



Barriers to Implementing a Just Culture

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What just culture actually means

just culture moves away from blaming people for mistakes it looks at the system behind an error instead of just punishing the person it started in industries like aviation and healthcare has been adopting it since



Barrier one: blame culture is still the norm

Barrier one blame culture is still the norm a lot of organizations still lean on punishment when something goes wrong years of that response make staff scared to speak up if people expect blame they just stop reporting things



Barrier two: managers don't apply it the same way

how an error gets handled kinda depends on who is running the investigation

same mistake can get two totally different outcomes just based on the manager



Barrier three: people don't understand what it means

a lot of staff just assume just culture means nobody gets in trouble if there isn't real training
people confuse fairness with just letting stuff slide so staff and even leaders end up pushing back
on the whole idea



Barrier four: legal and regulatory pressure

hospitals and organizations get nervous that being open about errors could lead to lawsuits so leaders end up going back to keeping things quiet which kind of defeats the whole point of getting people to report



Why these barriers matter

Why these barriers matter when people stop speaking up organizations miss the chance to actually fix what's causing the problem underreporting is one of the biggest reasons safety doesn't get better fear of getting in trouble is still the number one reason people don't report errors



Moving forward

these barriers don't go away on their own leadership commitment consistent policies and real training are what start to shift things



References:

Kumah, A. (2025, January 6). Adverse event reporting and patient safety: The role of a just culture. Patient Safety Learning – the hub.

<https://www.pslhub.org/learn/culture/occupational-health-and-safety/adverse-event-reporting-and-patient-safety-the-role-of-a-just-culture-r12504/>